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Collaborative Partnership between Early Childhood Education and the Practice Field: A Win–Win for Everyone

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ABSTRACT

It is challenging for early childhood education to collaborate across organisational boundaries between higher education and early childhood education and care institutions (ECECs). New methods of cooperation must be developed. This study examines how bachelor's degree students, university teachers, a project leader, and a municipal leader in Norway collaborate to create a learning process that benefits everyone involved. The methodological approach was qualitative interviews. The qualitative data consist of ten interviews with five bachelor's students, five associate professors from the early childhood education faculty, one municipal leader, and logs from one university project leader. A thematic analysis revealed four main perspectives on participants' perceptions of a partnership: engagement, communication, relationships, and common goals. All the partners need to be engaged, have mutually beneficial goals, have open communication, and, whenever possible, build trustworthy relationships. In addition, the results indicated that at the leadership level, a collaborative partnership with the practice field was achieved; however, between university teachers and students, the understanding of the term partnership should be clarified. These findings highlight the need for concept clarification, shared ownership of educational processes, and, as a result, a means to bridge theory and practice effectively. The results also clearly showed that the balance of power between the parties can be challenging in partnerships, especially between students and teachers, and that their roles make it difficult to enter genuine partnerships to begin with.

Keywords: *partnership; collaboration; early childhood education; leadership; power balance*

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Introduction

The term 'partnership' has become an essential topic for the Norwegian education system. In the policy document, *Teacher Education 2025. National Strategy for Quality and Cooperation in Teacher Education* (Kunnskapsdepartementet, 2017), the government desires to strengthen practical training and research cooperation among higher teacher education, early childhood education and care institutions (ECECs), and schools through partnerships. Moreover, more funds have been allocated for this purpose through local competence development in early childhood education and primary education (Utdanningsdirektoratet, 2023).

Collaboration between universities and the practice field depends on how participants involved in the work understand and implement partnerships. The research literature has focused primarily on the intentions and characteristics of the term 'partnership' (Daza et al., 2021; Lillejord & Børte, 2016). All the partners must know how they can develop an understanding of what exactly this concept means (Jakhelln & Postholm, 2022). Research has also shown that leaders in ECECs and universities play important roles in creating relationships, equal cooperation, and common goals, and leadership has been identified as a key prerequisite for successful partnerships (Fossestøl et al., 2021; Lyng et al., 2021). At the same time, there is a need for more empirical knowledge about how partnership is understood across different levels of collaboration, and what conditions appear to support or constrain its development. Although there has been significant research on partnerships, especially in schools (e.g., Lillejord & Børte, 2016; Postholm, 2020; Smith, 2016), few studies have explored how participants experience and learn in a partnership in an ECEC (Hermansen and Mausethagen, 2023). The early childhood and care field must explore and develop partnerships (Lillejord & Børte, 2016; Kunnskapsdepartementet, 2022; Postholm, 2020; Smith, 2016). Therefore, this paper addresses that gap by exploring how partnership is perceived by three groups involved in a collaboration between ECECs and the university: early childhood education bachelor's students, university supervisors, and leaders representing the university and the practice field. The research questions are as follows:

1) How do early childhood teacher education students and their university supervisors perceive the partnership between each other?
2) How do leaders in the project understand and organise partnership?

By examining these different perspectives, the study contributes knowledge about how partnership is understood and enacted among participants, and about the relational and organisational conditions that may enable collaboration to move towards partnership.

Conceptual framework

In this study, partnership is understood as a relational and organisational form of collaboration between the university and the practice field. In teacher education,

partnership has been described as a strategy for structuring, organising, strengthening, and professionalising education while also renewing teaching practices across institutional settings (Lillejord & Børte, 2016). It is also used as a collective term for collaboration on competence development between teacher education institutions and the practice field, with mutual learning as a main goal (Daza et al., 2021; Nilsen & Helstad, 2023). Previous Norwegian research suggests that such collaboration can be promising but also demands establishing and sustaining (Fossestøl et al., 2021; Lyng et al., 2021). In particular, the roles and contributions of universities in partnership arrangements are often described as unclear or insufficiently developed, which may result in fragmented collaboration (Fossestøl et al., 2021; Lyng et al., 2021). At the same time, research points to the importance of creating a safe environment in which participants can challenge one another's assumptions about practice and develop shared understandings over time (Folkvord & Midthassel, 2021; Lillejord & Børte, 2014; Midthassel, 2017). Partnership, in this sense, depends not only on formal structures but also on relational interaction, trust, continuity, and a shared understanding of purpose (Fossestøl et al., 2021; Lyng et al., 2021).

A central challenge in the partnership literature concerns conceptual clarity. Research has shown that well-functioning partnerships depend partly on how the participating actors understand their own roles and the nature of the collaboration itself (Daza et al., 2021; Flores, 2018; Izadinia, 2014; Lillejord & Børte, 2016; Mason et al., 2025; Nilsen & Helstad, 2023). One of the most persistent difficulties is that concepts such as collaboration, engagement, involvement, participation, and partnership are often used interchangeably, even though they imply different degrees of reciprocity, responsibility, and shared decision-making (Mason et al., 2025; Smith, 2016). As Smith (2016) argues, the fundamental conditions of a partnership must be known to and accepted by all stakeholders if collaboration is to improve practice. In the present study, partnership in an ECEC–university context refers to sustained collaboration based on mutually beneficial goals, trust, communication, and equitable participation in decision-making (Kezar, 2007). The literature also suggests that leadership is crucial in creating the conditions for such collaboration, as leaders in ECECs and universities may play key roles in supporting professional learning, motivation, competence development, and continuity in partnership work (Flaspohler et al., 2008; Silins & Mulford, 2002).

To interpret the findings, this study draws on Jones et al. (2016), who distinguish between different forms of partnership. Their typology is useful because it allows us to examine partnership as something that may vary in depth, reciprocity, and transformative potential. Jones et al. (2016) describe *collaborative* partnerships as relationships in which the parties establish cooperation around shared or complementary interests, and where both parties benefit from the collaboration or bring expertise needed by the other. *Developing* partnerships involve changes in practice, for example in campus teaching or practical training, and presuppose that the parties are responsive to one another's needs and perspectives and willing to revise established plans,

structures, or ways of working. *Transformative* partnerships, in turn, are grounded in critical reflection on existing practices and in mutual collaboration in which the active contribution of both parties is essential for success (Jones et al., 2016; Kruger et al., 2009). In this article, Jones et al. (2016) is used as an analytical framework for exploring how participants' accounts reflect different forms and conditions of partnership.

In addition to partnership, this study includes power as a supplementary perspective. This is important because partnership is often normatively associated with equality, mutuality, and reciprocity, while educational relationships are frequently shaped by structural and interpersonal asymmetries. Whether in institutional partnerships or in supervisor–student relationships, the balance of power influences participation, trust, and the outcomes of collaboration (French & Raven, 1959; Schrodt et al., 2007; Tormey, 2021; Trinidad, 2019). In recent years, growing attention has been paid to the role of student–teacher relationships in higher education, including how authority and responsibility are negotiated within them (Tormey, 2021). Weimer (2013) argues that learner-centred education requires a redistribution of power, in which students are given greater responsibility for learning and a more active role in decision-making processes. Such a shift also affects how the teacher's role, the function of content, and responsibility for learning and evaluation are understood (Weimer, 2013). In the present study, the concept of power is particularly relevant to the relationship between university supervisors and bachelor's students, where questions of guidance, responsibility, and authority shape the possibilities for partnership. At the same time, power must also be considered at the institutional level, where the relationship between the university and the practice field influences the conditions for equity, empowerment, and transformation in education (French & Raven, 1959; Schrodt et al., 2007; Tormey, 2021; Trinidad, 2019). The concepts of partnership and power provide a framework to examine both what participants mean when they refer to partnership and which relational and organisational conditions appear to influence its development in practice.

This study

The project, 'Everyday Practices', organised by the national early childhood education research center FILIORUM- Center for Research in Early Childhood Education and Care[1], funded by the Research Council of Norway and the Department of Early Childhood Education at the University of Stavanger, has been established to explore the collaboration between university and practice field through partnership. The main goal of the Everyday Practices project was to involve ECEC teacher students in research with ECECs, which contributes to gaining more knowledge about everyday

1 https://www.uis.no/en/research/filiorum-centre-for-research-in-early-childhood-education-and-care

practices that promote play, communication, and belonging in the ECEC. Through this project, it was central to establish contacts between the ECECs and the students to match interests on both sides. The municipal leader presented areas where the ECECs needed more knowledge and wanted the students to explore. Moreover, the students needed to write their bachelor's theses (BAs) about the themes in which they were engaged. In addition, teachers at the campus responsible for supervising the quality of the students' theses were also interested in the same research topics.

This study examines how the participants experienced a partnership between the university, bachelor's degree students and the municipal leader, where all the partners collaborated to create a learning process that was beneficial for everyone.

Method

Participants and their roles

This study is designed as a qualitative exploratory study examining partnership practices across multiple stakeholders. The study combines semi-structured interviews with reflexive self-reported data from the project leader, where the researcher is actively involved in the studied context. Eleven participants were interviewed: five university teachers, four females and one male (37–50 years old); five early child education bachelor's students, all females (27–51 years old); and one municipal leader (female, 45 years old). The university project leader (a 40-year-old female) was also included as a participant due to her active role in planning, organising, administering, participating in, collecting, and analysing the data for this project. This dual role is acknowledged as part of the research. The participants were recruited voluntarily on the basis of availability and willingness.

The university's role was to connect all the partners and be in contact with the municipal leadership. The municipal leader played a central role in initiating the project; she contacted the university, proposed themes that kindergartens were interested in, kept contact with the university through the process, and was responsible for placing students within five different ECECs willing to participate. The ECECs had the role of opening up their environment for the students to collect data. The role of the students was to find possible projects in collaboration with their supervisors within the frame of the municipalities' suggested themes, collect data and write their bachelor's theses. The role of the university teachers was to supervise students and create a stimulating learning environment in the process, and after all these were finished, they brought the knowledge back to the municipality. The collaboration between all the partners is shown in Figure 1. The arrows in the figure show who communicated with whom. The project leader had direct communication with everyone except the ECEC teachers. The university supervisors had contact with students and the project leader. Students collaborated with university supervisors, ECEC teachers, and the university project leader. The municipal leader of the project found the ECEC teachers and was in direct communication with the university leader. Additionally, the

colours of the figure distinguish the three partners in the project: the university, the students, and the practice field.

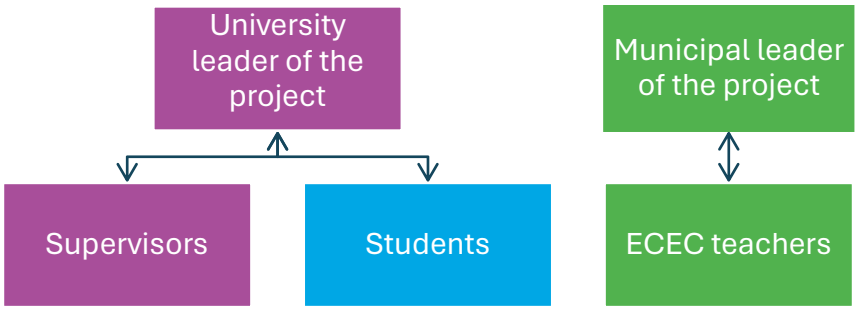


Figure 1. Overview of the collaborative structure at all levels.

Procedure

Establishing the partnership

Before the project "Everyday Practices", the university's ECEC BA students had to find participants to observe or interview independently. Every year, the students have had challenges recruiting enough ECEC teachers and/or children to have enough data to write the thesis. The ECECs in the immediate area of the university reported many inquiries that they had to reject and asked the university to act on this. In addition, the themes for the students' theses were repetitive, and the ECEC-experienced students asked nearly the same questions over the years for their interviews. The students' focus in their theses was not of the same interest as that of the ECECs. The supervisors reported that little new knowledge had been added in general to the educational research field and complained about the consequences of the considerable freedom for the students to choose the theme.

In parallel with the collegial discussions about these challenges, a nearby municipality contacted the Department of Early Childhood Education at the university to ask if we had any students who, in collaboration with them, could explore the use of digital tools in their ECECs. For example, how do staff members apply their digital knowledge in everyday ECEC life, and how and in which way do children play with digital toys and games, cameras, eBooks, and apps? The municipality suggested that they could be responsible for recruiting ECECs for data collection. We agreed to present this to the students as a possible theme for their BA theses and assign supervisors with competence in technology in ECEC. In addition, the leader at the university sends the finished BA thesis to the municipality after it has been assessed.

There was a need for more themes than technology and more partner ECECs. We contacted more ECEC owners (municipalities and private) and obtained more partners. Unfortunately, some partners dropped out during the project. We were not able to make contact with more participants because of timing. Nevertheless, we have added more themes. The further processes in the partnerships were the same as those in the municipality described earlier. The suggested themes were discussed in

a workshop with the possible supervisors, who also added some themes they wanted to include. In summary, the students agreed that they could choose the topic of their bachelor's thesis within thematic areas such as digital competence, play, belonging/diversity, creativity, sustainability, and leadership.

In this way, the issues essential for this municipality to explore in their ECECs are aligned with the students' topics for writing a bachelor's thesis. The students also had freedom of choice in terms of the research questions. The university teachers were informed about the project before the start of the process. Five university teachers who showed interest in the project were matched to supervise and collaborate with students because their subject knowledge and research interests were relevant to the students' theses.

Assessing the process of interviews

Four interviews with university teachers and one interview with a BA student were conducted in person, each lasting 40 minutes. Notes were taken and audio recordings were made during these five interviews. The participants answered the remaining six interviews in writing and emailed them. The questions were adapted according to the participants' positions (students, university supervisors, and a municipal leader). The questions were prepared on the basis of the literature on the topic of partnership (Smith, 2016). Additionally, the questions were open, with the opportunity to ask clarifying and in-depth questions (Creswell & Guetterman, 2024). Moreover, the first author of the article answered the interview questions as did the other participants. The researcher's self-reported log (Tjora, 2021) represents reflexive data generated from the project leader's dual role as both researcher and participant in the partnership process. Rather than functioning as an independent participant account, the log provides insight into leadership-level experiences and decision-making processes within the project. The second author of this article followed the data collection process, and the researchers cooperated closely in the analysis and presentation of the findings.

Ethics

This study is part of the "Everyday Practices" project approved by the SIKT-Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education (reference number 250478) and follows the same ethical guidelines. Pseudonyms were used to refer to participants and protect their privacy. Moreover, all the participants were asked to read and sign a consent form, which included an option to withdraw from the study at any time without providing a reason. The data were stored on a secure server.

Data analysis

The notes and transcriptions from the interviews, along with written answers were imported and analysed using the qualitative data analysis software NVivo (Version 14).

Since the self-reported data from the authors' log are also in the form of written documents, they were imported into the software together with the rest of the data. Thematic analysis was used to "identify themes and patterns of meaning across a dataset about research question" (Braun & Clarke, 2016, p. 175), using both inductive and theoretical thematic analysis. The interview questions explored how all the participants understood the term "partnership". These questions were prepared on the basis of the literature on partnerships (Smith, 2016). Furthermore, the interview guide included questions about participants' experiences and views on the topic. The self-reported log was analysed alongside the interview data using the same thematic analysis procedure. The log contributed to triangulating perspectives and provided additional depth to the interpretation of leadership and partnership processes.

The data analysis followed Clarke and Braun's (2013) six-step framework: 1) data familiarisation; 2) systematic data coding; 3) generating initial themes from coded and collated data; 4) developing and reviewing themes; 5) refining, defining, and naming themes; and 6) writing the report. Through these steps, a better understanding of the data was achieved. Furthermore, the recurring themes that represented shared meaning and fit as central organising concepts to address the research questions were formed.

Results

An analysis of the data yielded several findings regarding participants' understanding of the term partnership. A thematic analysis of the full dataset identified four overarching domains: engagement, relationships, communication, and common goals. These domains were evident across all participant groups, although they were expressed in different ways.

To present the findings clearly, we organise this section into three parts based on participant group. First, we present students' experiences of partnership. Second, we examine university supervisors' understandings and experiences. Third, we present leadership reflections on partnership in the project.

Students' experiences of partnership

The bachelor's students identified collaboration with open communication, clear information, and reflective dialogue as the main criteria for partnership.

Students' experiences in this project were positive. First, students' understanding of the term "partnership" boils down to communication, collaboration, and thesis writing.

> Student 2: "Partnership means good cooperation between two people, where they are open and honest with each other and support each other."

> Student 3: "I am not familiar with the word partnership... but maybe it means collaboration between university and practice ECEC?"
> Student 5: "Partnership is a close collaboration between the educational sector and the practice field. It supports the students, who are out in the field to practice and acquire knowledge but also challenges them."

The main factors mentioned by all the bachelor's students that were important for a positive experience were *information flow and open dialogue*. Omitting one of those conditions would hinder the possibility of a partnership.

> Student 1: "I collaborated well with the university teacher. Good supervision in the process. Additionally, we had good communication and availability with the ECEC."
> Student 3: "Honestly, when I heard that I would be placed in the ECEC, and I do not need to find one myself, that was enough for me. Clear information was important. I knew what to do, where to go, and whom to contact. Both the supervisor and the practice teacher in the ECEC were welcoming and honest."
> Student 4: "I was confused. I signed up for the project but did not receive the needed information. It took me some time to clearly understand my role in this."
> Student 2: "I would like more information about the project, so I do not feel so alone. My bachelor's thesis was my first encounter with research, so I struggled a bit at the start."

University supervisors' understandings and experiences of partnership

University supervisors noted equality, openness, and humility with respect to other people's input and knowledge, dialogue, time to get to know each other, and discussion and reflection between partners as prerequisites of a partnership.

Supervisors reported different experiences with partnerships with students. Since university teachers were not connected to the practice field, their only relations in this project were with their students and the project leader. The participants' opinions were divided into two groups: some supervisors indicated that the way supervision occurred could be called a partnership. Others indicated that it is difficult to build partnerships with students because of the power distribution.

> Teacher 3: "Students were very interested in writing a good thesis. They were engaged in the topic and research process. My position was to support them in their learning process. We worked as equals, even though I had to lead them to read their work many times and fix the text. I tried to create the environment for a partnership between us."

The other participants did not experience a partnership. The communication was based on the students' assignments. The mentors agreed that their role was to educate students by helping them write their bachelor's theses:

> Teacher 1: "I had a good tone in collaboration with students. Positive experience. However, it was only supervision. My role was to supervise; that is what I did. I cannot call it a partnership."

These findings indicated that teachers' attitudes towards students were more focused on supervision. The significance of a positive attitude towards students is enhancing the connection between both parties, which makes it easier to build collaboration.

Teachers understand partnership as an equality between partners, who learn from and listen to each other.

> Teacher 2: "Partnership is about two parties who are more or less equal and have more or less equal responsibility for creating good results – you must create something new together. It would be exciting to create a partnership with bachelor's students, but I think it would not be easy because of our position of power and distance in knowledge. However, we have a lot to learn from the students, too, so it is something we can strive for. There is no definitive answer."

This means that for supervisors to see the students as partners, students need to be engaged and willing to perform good work. The more motivated the students were, the more involved the teachers became, and the quicker it was to build trust between the two. Students' hard work inspired teachers when students took responsibility for the results. Teachers are open to partnership with students. However, they point to power positions as obstacles in such partnerships.

> Teacher 4: "Openness, humility for each other's input and knowledge, dialogue, time to get to know each other, discussions and reflections together promote partnerships."

Partnerships can be a different way of approaching and thinking about bachelor's students. It is an innovative way that requires time and effort from everyone.

Leadership reflections on partnership

The municipal leader of the project was excited by and interested in collaborating with the university. It was her initiative to contact the faculty and pitch the idea. The university's openness to the themes that the municipality was eager to explore was significant for her. This participant said:

> "To be heard and accepted is an important part of the partnership".

She felt that we were partners in this project. We communicated honestly, which allowed us to plan, organise, and complete the project together. Moreover, the municipality aimed to investigate how digital tools had been used in ECEC, which was ultimately achieved. The municipal leader reflected on her experience in the project and said the following:

> "The ECECs were excited to receive the students and to be part of the research project."

The university leader was invested in the process. For her, the main goal was to develop a project to help students experience the relevance of research to everyday life in ECEC. The notes and reflections around the process indicate that it was interesting and important to build a research project together with the municipal leader, who was so engaged and willing to collaborate. It was motivating to do the best work since the practice field took contact first. It was a partnership built on shared interests and goals, open dialogue, and equal responsibility for creating results. The municipal leader connected BA students with the leaders of the particular ECECs so that they could find the time to collaborate; the university recruited students who were excited to investigate those ECECs. Trust and assistance in the case of some unexpected situations were in place. Another important finding is that the university leader learned from this experience and could apply this knowledge to later projects.

The results confirm that the collaborative partnership has been established at the administrative-leadership level. Both leaders described open communication, trust, and common goals as a part of the partnership-building process.

Discussion

This study aimed to gain more knowledge on early childhood teacher education students, their university supervisors, and project leaders' views and experiences of partnership in a project-based environment in early childhood education. The conceptual understanding of what a partnership is determines the level of commitment, integration, and complexity needed. The existence and quality of the conditions determine whether the conceived partnership can actually move from intention to reality (Jones et al., 2016). The general findings suggest that, at a leadership level, both understanding and conditions were met. However, at the student-teacher level, they were not. Applying Jones et al.'s (2016) different forms of partnership typology (*collaborative*, *developing*, and *transformative partnerships*), the collaboration between teachers and students cannot be called a partnership. See Figure 2.

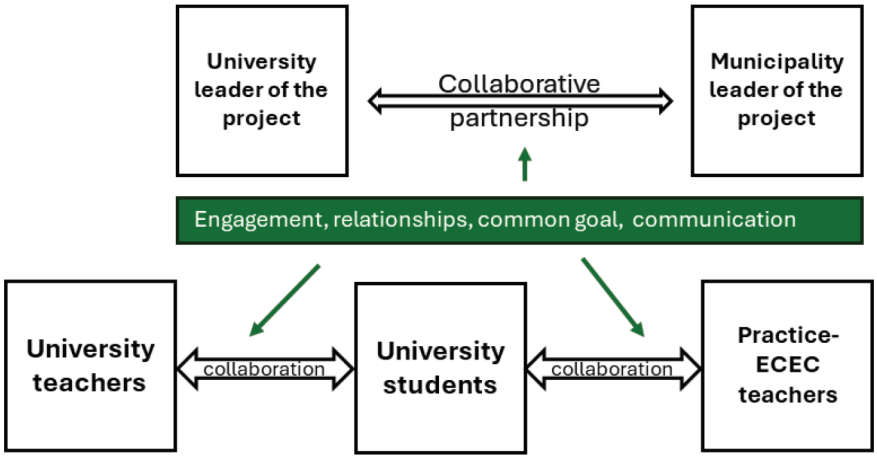


Figure 2. Overview of the results.

Supervisors-student-ECEC practice level—collaboration

University faculty played an important role in facilitating collaboration and promoting a sense of safety and stability. Partnerships can offer students access to dialogue between universities and the practice field and between theory and practice (Mörk, 2021). Such partnership projects between theory and practice allow students to learn, university teachers to stay updated on ECEC's everyday life, and the practice field to obtain an upgraded overview of the everyday situation at their workplace.

The findings of the study indicate that the participants had differing understandings of the concept of partnership or lacked an understanding altogether. This allows us to reflect upon the complexity of what it takes to establish a partnership. It highlights relational factors as critical success conditions for collaboration and recognize the existence of power dynamics. Jones et al.'s (2016) framework, which has been adopted in this study, is normative in that it describes what a successful partnership in teacher training programs is, but it also provides the tools to ensure that the aim is the right type of partnership for your specific context goals. They argue that the partnership is successful if the chosen form aligns with its purpose. The results affirm that at the leadership level. Despite the reported success at the project leadership level, a significant finding concerns *power balance*. The data strongly indicate that the perceived efficacy of partnership is fundamentally challenged as a result of structural and relational asymmetries. While an ideal partnership demands equality and mutualism, the institutional and pedagogical realities are hierarchical.

Hagenauer et al. (2023) reported that, structurally, educators hold formal power through assessment, academic authority, and institutional position, while the practice field often possesses the power to define what is considered relevant and applicable competence. Students take an intermediate position, being expected to learn, adapt, and contribute but without real influence over the frameworks that govern interaction. Power dynamics in higher education are often accepted as necessary for the maintenance of academic standards and for ensuring a functional learning process

(Hagenauer et al., 2023). On the other hand, students are expected to contribute meaningfully while simultaneously being assessed and socialised into professional norms. According to Smith (2016), the academy has power, and the students are subject to how this power is executed. The results confirmed that supervisors continue to make many decisions, and most believe that this differential power continues to be necessary. This dynamic raises critical questions concerning the possibility and desirability of establishing genuinely equal relationships in such partnerships.

The findings confirmed the challenge of the building of true equality between students and supervisors, supporting Daza et al. (2021), who discuss the focus of the traditional mentorship model on the teacher as the sole source of knowledge. However, the importance that participants placed on relationship building and mutuality suggests that a simple structural approach is insufficient. Karpouza and Emvalotis (2019) contend that while the teacher–student relationship is inherently hierarchical, the enactment of power is subject to negotiation. The quality of the relationship is context bound and highly individualised (Hagenauer et al., 2023), depending upon the subjective views and expectations of both teacher and student. The change in understanding and practice of learner-centred education demands effort from teachers and students. Furthermore, a teacher–student relationship must be understood as an adult–adult relationship that is still inherently hierarchical (Karpouza & Emvalotis, 2019), with power advancing in favour of the teacher. However, within this power relationship, teachers and students in higher education have a wide range of possibilities for how to form the relationship, as each relationship is characterised by mutuality (Hagenauer et al., 2023). This means that the amount of power that is enacted in the interactions is partly dependent on the educational teachers and their views and understanding of the nature of teacher–student relationships and partnerships and partly on the students' views or expectations regarding these relationships. The results of the research revealed that building relationships with supervisors and ECEC teachers was important for the students and university teachers; however, this was not achieved. Both groups expressed only a desire to do so.

Even though power relations are changing, and higher education institutions depend on the money students bring, the change needs to come from the structure of higher education and the mindsets of university teachers and students themselves (Cook-Sather, 2002; Smith, 2016). It demands that students behave as equals to the teachers, knowing that their work will ultimately be evaluated. However, as the university teachers noted, student engagement makes a difference. It helps teachers shift to guiding and facilitating learning instead of assigning tasks and controlling students' work (Weimer, 2013). Engaged and motivated students take more responsibility for learning and writing (Trinidad, 2019).

Despite these challenges, the university provided meaningful opportunities for students to engage in research and develop practical skills. ECEC–university collaboration was intentionally designed to create authentic research experiences, particularly in terms of qualitative methodologies such as interviews and observations.

These interactions also demonstrated the potential that such models had to enhance the overall quality of bachelor's-level teacher education. Partnerships are valuable only if they have an impact (Jones et al., 2016). In this study, the impact was achieved and was positive for all the parties.

This article highlights that the establishment of a collaborative partnership is a complex process influenced by various contextual, structural and relational factors, but there is room for university educators to let go of controlling too much, and students should have more responsibility. Moreover, according to Kruger and colleagues (2009), building relationships in a partnership on the basis of trust, mutuality, and reciprocity is time-consuming. That is precisely what the students of the project lacked, which may explain why they did not experience partnership. Moreover, some participants experienced a lack of communication at the beginning of the project, which created misunderstanding. Through communication, participants build trust and help promote equality within a relationship by ensuring that both partners have an equal standing in decision-making processes and discussions. It enables collaborative problem-solving rather than one-sided control (Smith, 2016). Most university teachers and bachelor's students indicated that they had a collaboration, not a partnership. This research acknowledges that creating a partnership is a demanding and complicated process that takes time (Smith, 2016). Regardless of their position, the partners must reflect on their expectations and have a positive attitude towards each other, with room to hear each other. Therefore, this study highlights that the possibility that the effective initiation of a partnership is dependent on the clear alignment of goals and the establishment of a relational foundation. Specifically, mutual commitment (engagement), the capacity to build relationships, and the implementation of high-quality communication are key elements. These elements collectively can form the prerequisite conditions for achieving collaboration goals, resulting in a win–win for everyone.

Leadership level–collaborative partnership

Following Jones et al.'s (2016) description of a collaborative partnership, which involves goals that are truly mutual, focusing on reciprocal benefits, and both parties sharing equal ownership of the problem and the solution, as well as having mutual trust and respect, this study has achieved partnership on a leadership level. The municipal leader and the university leader described a collaboration characterised by shared goals, explicit role clarification, open communication, and mutual trust. They agreed in advance on the purpose of the project, coordinated responsibilities, and worked together to plan and organise the project. These findings indicate that the conditions for partnership were present at this level and that the collaboration moved beyond simple coordination towards joint ownership.

Moreover, the findings also resonate with Penuel et al. (2020), who emphasise collaborative problem definition and role clarification as central features of

university–practice partnerships. The agreement around roles and leadership positions in the process was explicit, which made it easy to collaborate and administer the study.

At the same time, the results also indicated that communication and clarity at the leadership level were crucial for the organisation of the partnership. The leadership-level partnership was not sustained by positive attitudes alone; it depended on the leaders' ability to translate shared intentions into concrete organisational conditions. They ensured that the project addressed issues relevant to the municipality and enabled students' participation in authentic research in ECEC settings. The study suggests that partnership can be realised unevenly across levels within the same project. Furthermore, the study also confirms that partnerships rely on leaders who acknowledge the importance of collaborating with ECEC and understand the complexity of the process (Lillejord & Børte, 2016; Risan, 2022). Creating a robust and sustainable partnership requires municipal leaders who see the potential for mutual professional learning across institutional boundaries and support it (Dresden and Thompson, 2021). The leadership found the partnership beneficial in developing university-practice relationships, in which mutual respect and trust drive the collaboration. Penuel et al. (2020) proposed a set of value characteristics of university-practice partnerships. They report that problem definition is a collaborative process involving all stakeholders. The study results provide an empirical understanding of the importance of *having a goal* and defining a problem. Agreement on what the students wanted to explore and what the practice field wished to obtain research knowledge on was discussed in advance (Penuel et al., 2020). Moreover, both leaders had a common understanding of the partnership and created the conditions for it to move from intention to reality (Jones et al., 2016). The leaders' ability to create a structured and supportive environment facilitated professional learning across institutional boundaries and promoted the development of robust university–practice relationships (Dresden & Thompson, 2021). These collaborative processes resulted in positive outcomes for both the university and the practice field, showcasing the importance of leadership in achieving functional and effective partnerships.

Overall, the findings show that partnership in this project was realised only at the leadership level. Although the project created meaningful opportunities to promote collaboration and connect theory with practical experience (Mörk, 2021), students and supervisors face challenges in establishing true partnerships. The lack of a shared understanding of partnerships among students and practitioners contributed to misaligned expectations and relational tensions (Daza et al., 2021; Smith, 2016). Additionally, power imbalances between university supervisors and students further complicated the development of equitable and learner-centred partnerships (Cook-Sather, 2002; Weimer, 2013). While students' engagement and motivation were identified as critical to shifting traditional mentorship models towards more collaborative approaches, the structural and cultural changes required to achieve this remain a challenge (Smith, 2016).

Limitations and strengths

This small-scale qualitative study was conducted in a context where the researchers, particularly the first author, were actively involved in leadership and research roles. As such, the findings should be interpreted cautiously, particularly with respect to their generalizability to other contexts lacking this dual involvement (Barab et al., 2004). While this positionality could raise ethical concerns, it can also be considered an analytical strength, offering insider insights to deepen contextual understanding (Braun & Clarke, 2021).

Although the findings may not be directly transferable to all educational settings, they offer relevance for similar faculties that are engaging in collaborative work between universities and professional early childhood practice (Akkerman & Bakker, 2011). One limitation of this study is the limited inclusion of ECEC practitioners' voices, as only one municipal leader was consulted. Future research will benefit from more comprehensive practitioner perspectives to capture a fuller picture of partnership dynamics.

Implications

This study provides valuable insights for early childhood teacher education by addressing how partnerships are perceived and enacted by university teachers, BA students, the project leader of the university, and the municipal leader. Effective partnerships offer opportunities for professional development, study coconstruction, and pedagogical innovation. Universities that engage with practitioners can align their programs more closely with the realities of the field, enhancing the quality of teacher preparation and ultimately benefiting young children's educational outcomes.

The findings also call for a reexamination of traditional higher education structures. To create meaningful partnerships, institutions must embrace more collaborative, inclusive, and context-responsive approaches (Andreasen, 2023). Strong leadership, clearly defined roles, trust, and open communication are critical to supporting these initiatives.

While such partnerships promise to professionalise early childhood teacher education and close the gap between theory and practice, their success depends on long-term investment, mutual commitment, and the willingness to navigate complex relational and structural challenges. Moving beyond surface-level collaboration towards truly transformative practices requires systemic change and a shared vision among all stakeholders (Folkvord & Midthassel, 2021; Lyng et al., 2021; Midthassel, 2017).

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